vibes

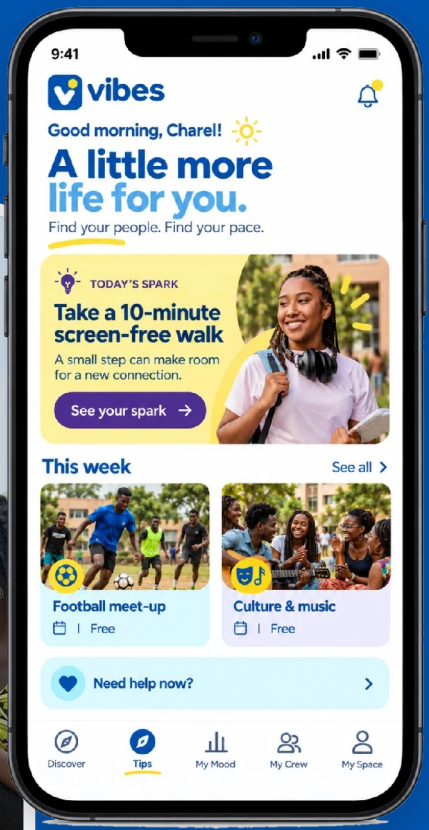
Application
Innovation Challenge 2026

STUDENT WELL-BEING · BENIN

Makes lives happen.

A light, student-built app that helps university students put the phone down and find their people, their pace and their habits, in real life.





Team VIBES · UNSTIM, Abomey, Benin
Three students
Mathematical Engineering and Modelling

Submitted to Education Training Research etr.

YTH LIVE GLOBAL 2026

AT A GLANCE

One idea, in one page.

Imagine a generation that puts the phone down, not out of obligation, but because something better is waiting outside. **VIBES is the first step toward that world.**

1 The problem

Students lose nights to the scroll. Nothing as attractive waits outside, and few dare to say what they need. A very connected generation, and a very lonely one.

2 The people

University students at UNSTIM first, then other campuses in Benin. Priority: those with no one to go with, who live far from activities, newcomers, and anyone who hesitates to show up alone.

3 The idea

A lightweight web app with three gestures: **Discover** shared passions and activities, **Equip** yourself with a private space and tips, **Anchor** small habits.

4 The value

A first step that is easier: find a small group, know the real cost before going, take a private moment, and get pointed to trusted help when it is too much.

5 The difference

Most apps win when you stay. VIBES wins when you leave. Success is measured in **lived hours**, not screen time.

6 The plan

We build the MVP ourselves. The award funds what comes next: wider surveys, a youth-led awareness campaign, a supervised pilot and a safe foundation.

3
months of design work led by students

5
dimensions of well-being: social, physical, emotional, mental, food

10
students in our first survey, plus 10 mockup screens and a Design System v1

First survey: 10 students (page 3). It is a signal, not proof; a larger survey comes next.



Makes lives happen.

THE CHALLENGE

The scroll became their only option.

Our observation on campus is not "young people scroll too much". It is that **nobody helps them listen to themselves**, and nothing as appealing waits outside. The problem has four layers, from the most visible to the deepest.

1 Attraction

Scrolling is designed to hold you. A student who stays is not lacking willpower. Some of the scrolling is also work (research, freelance); we are not against the phone.

2 The void

When the phone goes down, they do not know what to do that is as good, or with whom. So they go back.

3 The silence

Young people know what they need: talk, move, meet, create. What is missing is a place to admit it without being judged.

4 The invisible

Well-being tools exist, but many students do not know them, or do not see themselves in them.

WHAT THE DATA SAYS

1 in 6
people worldwide is affected by loneliness (WHO, 2025)

17–21%
of people aged 13 to 29 report feeling lonely (WHO, 2025)

7 of 10
students we asked spend more than 6 hours a day on their phone in free time (our survey, n = 10)

55.9% of 766 students of the Faculty of Health Sciences in Cotonou showed depressive disorders in a published study. *One health faculty and depression only: it shows that student well-being in Benin is a real subject, not that it applies to all students.*

OUR FIRST SURVEY: 10 STUDENTS, FOUR SCHOOLS

- **5 of 10** say their phone time is too long for them
- Top barriers to offline activities: **no one to go with (4)**, **too far (4)**, shyness (3), lack of time (3)
- Interest in VIBES after a short description: **7 yes, 3 maybe, 0 no**
- **10 of 10** put social media or videos in their top 3 for free time; 5 add series, anime or manga
- **3 of 10** often lack company; 1 sometimes; 5 rarely; 1 preferred not to answer
- Budget for a group activity: **7 of 10** up to 1,000 FCFA; 2 would pay nothing

What it does not show: nobody picked budget or "I don't know what exists" as a main barrier. With 10 respondents, a convenience sample, answers after a favourable description and no link to cause, we read this as a first signal, not proof. A larger survey is the first use of the award.

Sources: WHO, 30 June 2025; Klikpo et al., Health Sciences and Disease, 2020. Survey: team data, n = 10.

OUR RESPONSE

Three gestures. Another way to live campus life.

VIBES is prevention, designed by students. We test every feature with one question: **did the young person spend less time on the screen and more in real life?**

Discover

Find young people who share your passions: football, music, anime, photography, choir. Join events, clubs, or a small **Crew** so the first time is never alone.

Equip

My Safe Place: a private space to note your mood and receive small, practical gestures. **Tips VIBES**: short cards written by young Beninese people, in their words.

Anchor

Small **Sparks** instead of pressure: a walk, a message to a classmate, a screen-free break. No streaks, no rankings, no guilt.

WELL-BEING IN FIVE DIMENSIONS

Social · Physical · Emotional · Mental · Food

Activities are the means, not the goal. The goal: a young person who feels less alone, more energetic and more confident, with the habit of taking care of themselves.

OUR VISION

A student arrives in an unfamiliar city. Within days they have found young people who share their passions, a group to play football with, and a place to say how they are. They feel at home. And this well-being depends neither on their money, nor their contacts, nor luck.



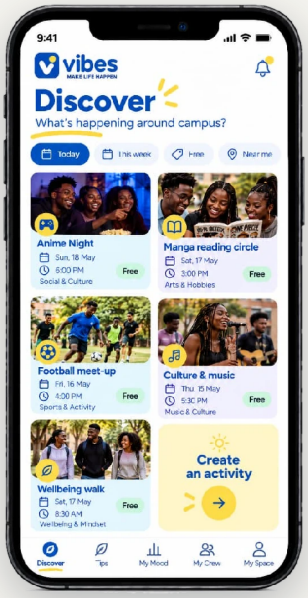
A language of our own

"Let's VIBES" replaces "Let's go out". The vocabulary will be tested with young people before it is adopted. Everything written in the app is drafted and polished by a youth editorial committee.

THE EXPERIENCE

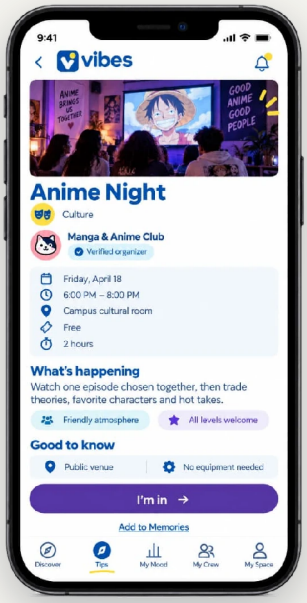
Made for the real moments of student life.

Technology opens the door. Experiences are lived outside.



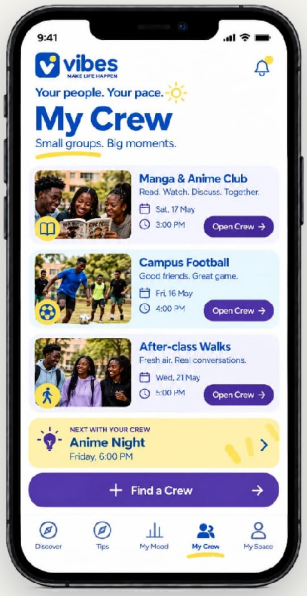
Discover activities

Filter by day, free or nearby. Date, place and cost shown up front.



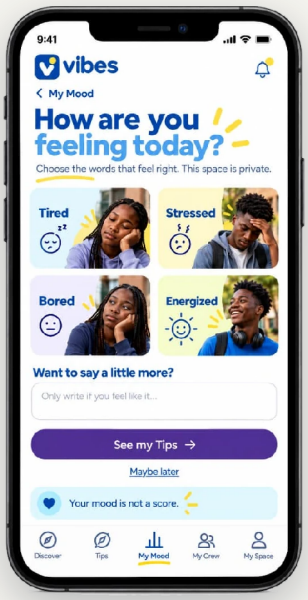
Join with confidence

Practical info first: public venue, free, all levels welcome.



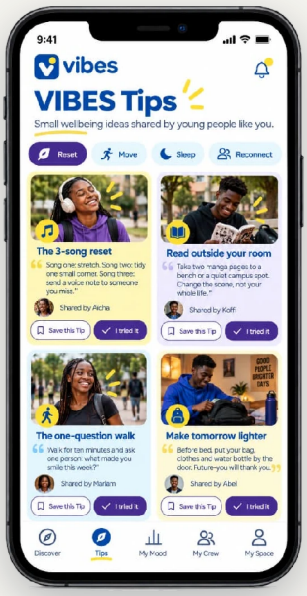
Go with a Crew

A small group around an activity. A chat only for people signed up, no private messages.



Take a moment

My Mood: optional, private, no score, no diagnosis.



Tips VIBES

Short tips shared by young people. Health content is planned to be reviewed by professionals.

How it plays out

1. You spot an activity that speaks to you.
2. You join a small group to get organised.
3. You meet up in person, for real.

Screens are working mockups and are subject to change. They show the direction; the first web MVP is being built.

WHAT SETS US APART

A platform that wins when you leave it.

OUR CENTRAL INDICATOR

Lived hours

The real hours of matches, walks, choir rehearsals and creating that VIBES helped trigger; after each activity, the organiser confirms the group's attendance in a check-in. Time in the app is tracked only as a warning signal: if it rises without lived hours rising too, we fix it.

What we do differently

- Answer all four layers, not only the screen
- A place to tell the truth, without judgment
- A small group removes the fear of coming alone
- Real cost, distance and data use shown before you commit

HOW WE COMPARE

Solution	What it does	How VIBES differs
ChillChezCharlee France	Mobile app: you share a weekend wish and it groups 2 to 5 nearby people for a first meeting, then circles of 3 to 6. For students; reporting and verified profiles. Prix Pépite 2025 (its site).	The closest idea, and a sign the need is real. VIBES adds a private well-being space, tips by young Beninese, a Benin context (light web app, cost and distance first) and a different measure: lived hours.
Lynk letslynk.com	Live video platform: timed one-on-one chats, for dating, friends or hosted events.	Online and one-to-one. VIBES is about meeting in person, in small groups, and is not a dating service.
WhatsApp groups and club pages	Already used by clubs to organise.	VIBES builds on them as channels and adds discovery, a first group to join, and cost and distance up front.

Based on their public websites; we have not tested these products. A wider benchmark in Benin and West Africa is part of the project.

YOUNG PEOPLE LEAD

A Adéyinka Laurinda ADANLAO
ML Engineer in training & Front-end Developer

C Charmel Prosper AFFOUKOU
Team lead · Systems Thinker and Data Scientist

J Judicaël Karol DOBOEVI
Business Development & Product Marketing Manager

Three students at UNSTIM: systems thinking, data analysis, business development, design and web development.

How young people shape the idea

The idea comes from what we see around us. We have started checking it with students: a first survey of 10 (page 3), then interviews and mockup tests. App content is planned to be written with a youth editorial committee.

Health content will be reviewed

We come from maths, not health. We have asked final-year medical students to review health content. With the award, licensed health professionals will supervise it.

BUILT IN FROM THE DESIGN

Made for here. Safe from the start.

WHO MIGHT BE LEFT OUT, AND OUR ANSWER

Barrier	Our response
Little mobile data, older phone	Lightweight web app, compressed photos, optional SMS or WhatsApp reminders
Tight budget	Filter by real cost, free activities first, shared transport inside the Crew
Far from campus	Distance filter, activities on site
Language	French first, written with young Beninese people; local languages being studied
Shyness, disability, first-generation students	Beginner-friendly activities, accessibility information shown, accompanied first visit

SAFEGUARDS WE ARE DESIGNING IN (PLANNED, NOT YET BUILT)

Activities

Public activities only, in small groups for the first time. Student events will be checked before publication; the most exposed ones will require a public place, daytime hours and posted rules.

Crew chat

Planned: only for people signed up, no private messages, no phone numbers shown, reporting available, closed 48 hours after the event.

Data

We will collect the minimum. No precise location shared between strangers. What you write in My Safe Place stays private. Feelings questions are optional. Photos private by default.

Reliable information

Tips written with young people and reviewed by professionals for health content. Organisers will be verified.

When it is too much

A "Need help now?" access will stay visible on every screen and point to a trusted person or service. Ambassadors will be trained in listening and referral. The whole system will be tested with young people before any wide opening.

A clear limit

VIBES is a prevention and well-being initiative. It is not a care service, not a diagnostic tool, not medical or psychological advice, and not a dating app. Our starting rule for notifications: two a day (morning and evening) plus reminders for events you joined, to be tested with students. No challenge on tobacco, alcohol, drugs or betting without a professional, and none on restrictive eating or weight.

THE PLAN

We build first. The award takes it to the next level.

Already here

Design document · Design System v1 · 10 mockup screens · a first survey of 10 students

We fund and build ourselves

The lightweight web MVP · interviews and mockup tests with students · first field work on campus

The award does not start VIBES. It carries it from a prototype on one campus to a solid base for several universities.

ROADMAP IN MONTHS (TARGETS)

Nov – Dec 2026

Listen

Survey to 30+ students. Mockup tests with 5 to 10 students. Clickable prototype.

Self-funded

Jan – Mar 2027

Build

Web MVP v1: discover, join, My Mood, Tips. 20 to 30 testers on campus.

Self-funded

Apr – Jun 2027

Prepare

Wider surveys, ambassadors, health review, awareness campaign, hosting.

With the award

Jul – Sep 2027

Pilot

4 to 6 supervised weeks outside exam periods. Lived hours measured.

With the award

Oct – Dec 2027

Share

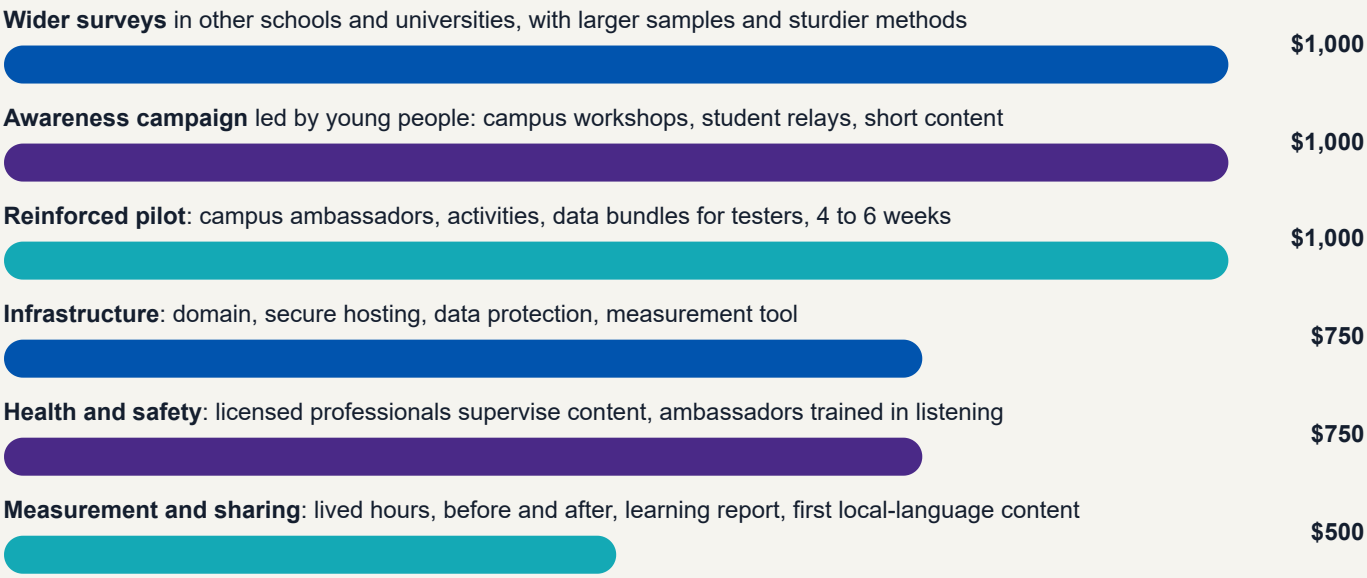
Open learning report. Decision on a second campus.

With the award

Dates are targets. Phases marked "With the award" start when funds arrive; if they come later, the schedule moves with them.

After the award. Beyond December 2027, we will seek to keep VIBES active through in-kind support and co-funding partnerships with FEUA, FEUNSTIM, campus clubs (dance, RFI, Génie en Herbe, choir, arts and theatre), our administrations (ENSGMM, ENSGEP, ENSTP and the rectorate), and community partners such as libraries, ABFM, youth centres, Amour et Vie centres, INF and social assistance centres; no post-award funding is confirmed yet.

WHAT $5,000 MAKES POSSIBLE (PROPOSED ALLOCATION)



If the award is smaller. At $2,000 or $1,000 we keep the same split and scale the pilot down: fewer campuses, fewer testers, a shorter run. The MVP stays self-funded either way.

THE PILOT QUESTION

Do students who use VIBES feel more connected after a few weeks, come back on their own, and take up new habits? We measure with two or three short questions before and after, a well-being tool validated with professionals, and total lived hours. **No result is claimed**

INDICATORS

Lived hours · self-reported well-being (connection, confidence, participation) · students who return on their own · real participation · habits installed · accessibility and safety feedback · and, as a warning signal, time in the app.

WHY US, WHY NOW

We build before we ask.

We build before asking. Three months of design work, a first survey of 10 students, and an MVP we are building ourselves.
We see the problem up close. We know those screen nights, those empty weekends, and the fear of the first step.

We know how to measure. We say what the data does not prove.
We start from the ground. Our campus, its habits, its WhatsApp groups.
We go against the grain. An app judged by what it gives back.

HOW VIBES ANSWERS THE SELECTION CRITERIA

Criterion	Our answer	Page
Relevance	Student isolation and screen overuse: four layers, WHO and Benin data, a first survey of 10 students	3
Youth leadership	Three students lead; app content is planned with a youth editorial committee	6
Usefulness	Find a group, know the real cost, take a private moment, build habits	2, 4, 5
Innovation	Success measured in lived hours; the app is judged by how well it sends you offline	6
Feasibility	Self-funded MVP; award mapped to a 4–6 week supervised pilot	8
Access	Light web app, cost and distance filters, French first, beginner-friendly	7
Safety	Planned: private data, verified organisers, reviewed health content, help access on every screen	7
Clarity	One page summary, annotated screens, a clear plan and budget	2, 5, 8

What if the next good thing started here?

Let's VIBES
charmel7.github.io/vibes
prosperaffou@outlook.com

Photos: Iwaria Inc and Muhammad-Taha Ibrahim via Unsplash. Sources: WHO, 30 June 2025 (who.int); Klikpo T. et al., Health Sciences and Disease, 2020 (doi 10.5281/hsd.v21i1.1753). Competitors: public websites of ChillChezCharlee and Lynk. Screens are mockups subject to change.